Asta

Gifted Youths' Peer Preferences, Social Niche Selection, and Receptive Contexts

Table of Contents

Introduction/Background

Preference for intellectual, similar, or older peers

Gifted programs, ability grouping, and receptive peer contexts

Social pressure, hiding ability, and changing environments

Introduction/Background

Gifted students often have the same basic need for acceptance and belonging as other students, but their school social experiences can be more unstable because peers and adults do not always respond well to high ability. This makes the social setting itself important: supportive peer recognition and inclusive environments are central to whether gifted students feel safe, connected, and able to be themselves. (3 sources)

A useful starting point is that social adaptation among gifted youth is not inherently poor. Gifted children can develop a healthy self-concept, but negative or distorted views from peers and educators can push them toward harmful coping responses instead. (Ely, 2010) Recent review work also points to peer recognition and better socialization as basic needs in gifted populations, suggesting that the issue is not giftedness alone, but whether the surrounding peer environment is accepting and responsive. (Baccassino et al., 2023) School experiences appear especially mixed: gifted students report emotions ranging from satisfaction to anxiety around success, and peers may react with either support or with jealousy and exclusion. These findings show that the interpersonal climate around ability matters for both social-emotional well-being and school adjustment. (Senicar et al., 2024) Taken together, this background helps explain why later evidence on gifted youths' peer choices, friendship patterns, and movement toward more receptive contexts is so important: if acceptance varies sharply across settings, then the search for fitting peers and environments becomes a reasonable social response rather than a minor preference. (Ely, 2010) (Baccassino et al., 2023) (Senicar et al., 2024)

Evidence

(Ely, 2010)

Understanding the Stereotypes Against Gifted Students: A look at the social and emotional struggles of stereotyped students

> *"Gifted children have the ability to develop a normal, healthy, well-adjusted self concept, however, skewed peer and educator perspectives of the gifted student can lead the gifted student to react with destructive behaviors and coping mechanisms (Cross, 2005)."*

(Baccassino et al., 2023)

Giftedness and gifted education: A systematic literature review

> *"one of the basic needs of the gifted population that emerges in the review is peer recognition and a better socialization experience."*

(Senicar et al., 2024)

The Experience of Success and Failure of Gifted Students at School

> *"The findings indicate that gifted students experience a range of emotions in response to success, from satisfaction to anxiety, while*

their reactions to failure often involve frustration and self-criticism. Peer responses to their success and failure vary significantly, ranging from supportive encouragement to jealousy and social exclusion. These findings highlight the complex interpersonal dynamics at play within school environments. Understanding and addressing these dynamics is crucial for creating inclusive, supportive, and stimulating learning environments that nurture both the academic and social-emotional well-being of gifted students."

Preference for intellectual, similar, or older peers

Gifted youth often do not just want "more friends"; they want peers who match their pace, interests, and way of thinking. Across studies, this shows up as a pull toward intellectually similar friends, other high achievers, small like-minded circles, and sometimes older peers or adults. (8 sources)

A repeated pattern in the literature is that gifted students often seek similarity in friendship, especially similarity in interests, ability, and style of thinking. Reviews and qualitative work describe gifted students as feeling different from the larger peer group, which can make broad peer integration harder and can push them toward smaller circles or selective friendships instead (Putra, 2025) (Haikal et al., 2026). This preference is not only about comfort; it is also linked to well-being, since companionship with similar-ability peers has been tied to gifted students' emotional adjustment, and it can be hard to find "intellectual peers" without special programs or activities that bring such students together (Burton, 2011).

Several sources also describe a tendency to prefer peers who are more cognitively similar even when they are older. One review states that gifted and talented students often prefer socializing with older children and adults because same-age peers with a lower mental age may feel like a poorer fit, and they "gravitate towards friends who are more similar to themselves" (Suyitno et al., 2024) (Ahkam et al., 2020). In a similar vein, another recent study reports that many gifted students preferred solitary activities or moved toward older peers whose interests better matched their intellectual level (Rahman et al., 2025). This helps answer the question of whether gifted youth actively seek better-fit social settings: at least at the friendship level, many appear to sort toward peers who feel more developmentally or intellectually compatible.

There is also evidence of preference for high-achieving or gifted friends specifically. In one study of gifted female students, many said their closest friends were also high-achieving peers, and the authors note that the fact that most friends were also gifted may reflect shared academic interests and abilities (Abbas et al., 2026). Network evidence from gifted adolescents points in the same direction more indirectly: these students formed reciprocated friendships and cohesive peer groups, and friendship choice was shaped by how creative peers were seen to be, suggesting active selection based on valued traits rather than random mixing (Hopp et al., 2019). Taken together, these findings support the idea that gifted youth often prefer "like-minded" peers and may deliberately narrow their social world to those who better accept, match, or share their abilities and interests.

Evidence

(Putra, 2025)

Exploring the Silent Struggles of Gifted Adolescents in School Counseling Programs

""different" in their way of thinking and interests, making it difficult to blend in with a wider group of friends. This condition makes them prefer to stay away or only interact with friends in small circles."

(Haikal et al., 2026)

Social behavior of children with special needs in school and community interactions: A literature review

"Research suggests that gifted children may display social withdrawal, perfectionism, or difficulty finding peers with similar interests"

".Therefore, inclusive education should also consider the social needs of gifted learners by providing enrichment opportunities, peer grouping, and supportive counseling when needed (Elkarif et al., 2024)."

(Burton, 2011)

Small Ponds: The Challenges Facing Gifted Students in Rural Communities

> *"several studies (Rimm, 2002;Gross, 2002) have found links between gifted students' emotional well-being and the companionship of peers of similar ability, and it can be difficult, without the aid of gifted programs and academic activities, for bright students to find intellectual peers or friends who share their interests."*

(Suyitno et al., 2024)

Gifted students: Analysis among psychological problems, social, and emotional well-being

> *"Gifted and talented students tend to prefer socializing with older children and adults because they are less interested in peers with a lower mental age and gravitate towards friends who are more similar to themselves (Ahkam et al., 2020)."*

(Ahkam et al., 2020)

KESEJAHTERAAN DI SEKOLAH BAGI SISWA SMA: KONSEP DAN FAKTOR YANG BERPENGARUH

> *"Tujuan penelitian ini adalah untuk mengetahui makna kesejahteraan di sekolah pada siswa, faktor yang berpengaruh dan dampak kesejahteraan di sekolah yang rendah. Subjek penelitian adalah siswa SMA di Surabaya sebanyak 202 siswa pada 4 (empat) sekolah. Hasil penelitian kesejahteraan di sekolah merupakan sebagai suasana yang nyaman selama siswa di sekolah yang menagcu pada aspek kepuasan di sekolah dan afek di sekolah. Kesejehteraan di sekolah dapat dipengaruhi faktor dukungan guru, dukungan teman, rasa syukur, kebersamaan, rasa syukur dan harga diri. Dampak yang dapat terjadi ketika kesejahteraan di sekolah rendah adalah psikologis siswa, perilaku negatif dan hasil akademik."*

(Rahman et al., 2025)

The Psychological Needs of Gifted Children: Addressing Asynchronous Development and Social-Emotional Challenges

> *"Many preferred solitary activities or gravitated toward older peers whose interests better matched their intellectual level."*

(Abbas et al., 2026)

The Impact of Bullying, Sociability, and Feelings on Gifted and Nongifted Middle School Female Students in Kuwait–A Comparative Study

> *"The study found that many gifted female students reported that their closest friends were also high-achieving peers"*
>
> *". The fact that the friends of the majority of the gifted students are also gifted may reflect shared academic interests and abilities."*

(Hopp et al., 2019)

Creative, Thus Connected: The Power of Sociometric Creativity on Friendship Formation in Gifted Adolescents-A Longitudinal Network Analysis of Gifted Students.

> *"Overall, our longitudinal multilevel and multigroup social network analysis shows that gifted adolescents formed reciprocated friendship ties and cohesive peer group structures in the investigated period; similar age and the same gender predicted friendship formation"*
>
> *"the sociometric creativity positively influenced adolescents' friendship networks on a dyadic level, indicating that adolescents select friends based on their perception of the other student's creativity."*

Gifted programs, ability grouping, and receptive peer contexts

Gifted programs and ability-grouped settings can change the peer climate, not just the academic level. When gifted students are placed with others who value high ability, they often report more acceptance, more freedom to show what they can do, and less pressure to hide it. (3 sources)

The evidence here suggests that peer-group composition matters in a very practical way. When gifted students share space with others of similar or higher ability, the setting can become more enjoyable, supportive, and accepting, while the absence of such a context can leave students feeling odd, isolated, or pushed to conceal their abilities in order to fit in (Khalil et al., 2016). This helps explain why gifted programs and homogeneous grouping can have social effects beyond instruction alone. Reports from grouped settings describe students expressing ideas more freely and classrooms developing a climate of mutual respect, and at least some students describe being surrounded by other gifted peers as motivating and identity-affirming rather than threatening (Gorgulu, 2026).

This also connects directly to the question of whether gifted youth seek or prefer more receptive

environments. Work on “camouflaging” argues that students may hide giftedness in some contexts but use that strategy differently across settings; when they are with peers who value the very abilities or interests that mark them as gifted, they may feel less need to minimize those traits (Kennedy et al., 2018). In that sense, gifted programs and specialized peer groups can reduce the social cost of visible ability: they do not just supply intellectual matches, but can create places where belonging comes more naturally and public display of talent feels safer (Kennedy et al., 2018) (Khalil et al., 2016). Overall, the pattern is consistent with social niche selection: gifted students often do better socially when they can enter or remain in peer settings where their abilities are normal, welcomed, and openly shared (Gorgulu, 2026) (Khalil et al., 2016) (Kennedy et al., 2018).

Evidence

(Khalil et al., 2016)

Identifying "Good" Teachers for Gifted Students

> *"The social environment plays a significant role in the learning process, and there is a greater chance that gifted students will have more significant opportunities to learn if they share their learning environment with others of similar or higher abilities, engendering a positive atmosphere that increases enjoyment, support and acceptance, and ultimately achievement. Where such a social environment does not exist, the isolation caused by feeling odd and unaccepted by peers may prevent them from achieving their potential (Burney, 2008). They may also try to conceal their skills and abilities from those around them (parents, teachers, and peers), out of the childish, yet natural, desire to feel equal to their peers and receive the same amount of attention."*

(Gorgulu, 2026)

Leadership experiences of gifted students: A meta-synthesis of qualitative studies

> *"Peer interactions are considered an influential factor in the emergence of leadership behaviors in gifted students. A student in Behrend's (2013) research expressed the impact of being in an environment with gifted students by saying, "Wow! These people are so smart. I want to be just like them." Similarly, in Begnaud's (1999) study, it was stated that in a separate classroom environment where gifted students were homogeneously grouped, students could express their ideas more freely and a learning climate based on mutual respect could be established."*

(Kennedy et al., 2018)

Counseling Gifted Students: School-Based Considerations and Strategies

> *"One strategy students may use to fit in with peers is to intentionally hide or minimize manifestations of giftedness, a process known as "camouflaging" (Coleman & Cross, 1988, 2005). This strategy is sometimes adaptive and may be used differently in different environments. For example, when among peers who value abilities and interests in an area in which a student is gifted (e.g., advanced science and math, creative writing), a student may feel less need to hide abilities or interests in these areas. School personnel should understand the social context and evaluate if there are specific groups of peers with whom a gifted student would feel accepted and belong more naturally."*

Social pressure, hiding ability, and changing environments

Gifted students do not only react to peer pressure; some actively manage it by hiding ability, distancing from a “gifted” image, or changing social settings. The evidence also suggests that when the peer climate feels more accepting, the need to conceal ability can ease, which fits the idea that gifted youth may seek out better social niches. (5 sources)

Another part of the picture is that gifted students sometimes change how visible their ability is depending on the social setting. Students who saw high ability as getting in the way of fitting in, or who denied being gifted, also reported feeling socially unaccepted by peers, even while still keeping some close friendships. That pattern suggests that concealment is often tied to perceived peer risk rather than to a simple lack of social interest. (Oh et al., 2019) Pressure to match group norms can also push gifted children to hide what they can do in order to be accepted, which is why authors stress the need for supportive peer environments where students feel understood and connected. (Putri et al., 2025) (Papadopoulos, 2021)

The same social pressure can shape broader coping choices, including movement toward different environments. One recent study reports that gifted students described coping not only by accepting the situation or trying to seem “normal,” but also by “changing environment” and by distancing themselves from

difficult contexts. That is direct evidence that at least some students respond to mismatch by altering their social setting, not just by changing themselves. (Unlu et al., 2023) Related work on risk behavior makes a similar point indirectly: differences in how strongly gifted students want social acceptance from nongifted peers, or want distance from a gifted image, may help explain why some use alcohol and others do not. This shows that orientation toward peer acceptance can be powerful enough to affect identity management and behavior, not just friendship preference. (Peairs et al., 2011)

Taken together, these studies support a simple conclusion relevant to the user's question: gifted youth can be quite active in managing peer fit. Sometimes they do this by reducing the visibility of ability; sometimes by trying to look more "normal"; and sometimes by moving toward different people or contexts altogether. While the evidence here is stronger for self-protective coping than for a fully planned "search strategy," it still points to social niche selection in practice: willingness to show giftedness appears to depend on whether the current peer group feels safe, and some students respond to poor fit by seeking distance or a new environment. (Oh et al., 2019) (Unlu et al., 2023) (Putri et al., 2025)

Evidence

(Oh et al., 2019)

Adolescent Perception of Potential High-Performing Classmates: A Cross-National Exploration

> *"(Swiatek, 2001) study revealed that gifted students who viewed their high ability as an obstacle to fitting in or who denied being gifted in the first place considered themselves socially unaccepted by their peers. They did, however, concede that they maintained close friendships with those peers."*

(Putri et al., 2025)

The Role of Peers in the Social-Emotional Development of Gifted Children in Early Childhood Education

> *"In addition, the pressure to adapt to group habits often encourages gifted children to hide their abilities to be accepted in social settings"*

> *".These issues highlight the need for a supportive social environment for gifted and talented children, especially the important role that peers can play in providing emotional and social support and making them feel accepted, understood, and connected. Therefore, it is important to create a conducive environment for gifted children to interact with their peers so that their social skills can develop optimally (Arias et al., 2024)- (Papadopoulos, 2021)."*

(Papadopoulos, 2021)

Parenting the Exceptional Social-Emotional Needs of Gifted and Talented Children: What Do We Know?

> *"Parenting gifted and talented (G/T) children is a journey with unique experiences that can differ from the lived experiences of parents raising non-gifted and talented children. These unique experiences typically raise concerns, influence decisions, and exacerbate stress and anxiety regarding the children's future development and education. The purpose of this paper is to provide an overview of the current literature in order to highlight the topic of parenting G/T children with a focus on their exceptional social-emotional needs. Studies support the conclusion that significant determinants of G/T children's personal growth are authoritative parenting, which provides autonomy and self-motivation, and parents' behaviors and attitudes toward the exceptional needs of G/T children. Conversely, authoritarian parenting negatively impacts children's well-being and mental health, impeding the positive development of the child's potential. Enhancing the caregiving capacity of family members—by reducing the stress associated with their parenting and caregiving roles—can have a powerful impact on the developmental trajectory of gifted children."*

(Unlu et al., 2023)

Özel Yetenekli Öğrencilerin Okul Ortamında Karşılaştıkları Sorunlar ve Çözüm Önerileri

> *"Katılımcı öğrenciler sorunlarının çözümünde ailelerinden, öğretmenlerinden ve akranlarından destek alarak, akranlarına tavsiyeler vererek, normal olmaya çalışarak, kabullenerek, ortam değiştirerek, uzaklaşarak, düşünmeyerek ve kişisel gelişimlerini ön planda tutarak baş etmeye çalıştıklarını aktarmışlardır."*

(Peairs et al., 2011)

Academic Giftedness and Alcohol Use in Early Adolescence

> *"Individual differences with regard to endorsing a high desirability of gaining social acceptance or fitting in with nongifted peers or distancing oneself from "gifted" image may explain why some gifted students use alcohol and others do not."*